

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Pretending certainty when genuine unknowns exist destroys credibility when the truth emerges — and it always emerges. Naming your uncertainty explicitly builds trust by signalling intellectual honesty, which makes your certainties more believable.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not hedging — hedging blurs everything, while this draws a sharp line between the known and the unknown.
- Not modesty theatre — you are not downplaying what you know; you are refusing to inflate it.
- It is precision about the edge of your knowledge, delivered with the same steadiness as your certainties.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: When they say they are sure, you can build on it — because they tell you plainly when they are not.

Principle: Credibility is not the absence of unknowns; it is the accuracy of your map of them.

What you gain

- Certainties that carry full weight, because your uncertainty is honest
- Fewer confident errors that surface later and cost more
- Questions that come to you first, because your answers can be trusted
- Composure under questioning — there is no bluff to defend
- Decisions built on real information rather than performed confidence

Why most people fail at it

- They treat 'I do not know' as failure, so they guess and get caught later.
- They apologise their way through the admission, which reads as incompetence rather than honesty.
- They say they do not know, then speculate anyway and lose both ways.
- They admit the gap but never close it — no follow-up, no answer, no credibility gained.

CORE FORMULA

Name what you know -> Name what you do not know -> Own the gap with confidence

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

When you do not know something, say so directly and then name what you do know. Do not bluff and do not apologise for not knowing.

BEST FOR

- High-stakes situations where bluffing would be worse than admitting uncertainty
- Expert or interview contexts where credibility is on the line
- Any situation where you are pressed for an answer you do not have
- Building long-term credibility by being reliably honest

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Known — Name what you know

Lead with the solid ground, stated plainly — it anchors the conversation in fact and shows the gap is specific, not general. Claim only what you can stand behind if pressed.

Overclaimed: 'The migration is basically done, more or less.'

Known: 'Data transfer is complete and verified. That part I can stand behind.'

2. Unknown — Name what you do not know

Draw the boundary explicitly rather than letting vagueness imply it. A named unknown is information; an unnamed one is a landmine.

Blurred: 'The rest should probably be fine, I think.'

Named: 'What I do not know yet is whether the legacy reports still run. That is untested.'

3. Own — Own the gap with confidence

State the unknown at normal volume, without apology, and attach a plan to close it. The confidence lives in the follow-through, not in pretending.

Apologetic: 'Sorry, I really should know this, sorry...'

Owned: 'I do not know yet. I will run the test tomorrow and confirm by Wednesday.'

FIELD TIP

Deliver 'I do not know' in the same voice as 'I am certain'.

The content admits a gap; the tone must not. Keep the pace, volume and posture identical to your confident answers and the admission reads as precision — let the voice drop and trail away and the same words read as being caught out.

Situation: A director asks for a number you do not have.

Don't: 'Um, sorry, I'd have to... I'm not really sure, sorry.'

Do: 'I do not have that figure. I will have it to you by three o'clock.'

PHRASE BANK

Confident Uncertainty Phrases · Owning not knowing

- "I do not know the answer to that — and I do not want to guess."
- "I am not certain about this and I would rather say so than bluff."
- "That is outside what I can say confidently."
- "My honest answer is: I do not know."
- "I can tell you what I do know, which is X. I cannot tell you Y."
- "I do not have that information in front of me."
- "I would rather admit that and come back with the right answer."
- "That is a better question than I can currently answer."

Bounded Answer · Saying what you can say

- "What I can say is..."
- "What I know for certain is..."
- "I can confirm X — I cannot confirm Y."
- "My best estimate is X, but I want to flag that I am not certain."
- "I will give you my best current read — with the caveat that..."

Quick Admissions · Short, unapologetic not-knowing

- "I do not know — I will find out."
- "Not sure. Let me check."
- "Good question — I do not have it to hand."
- "Cannot say yet."
- "I would be guessing."
- "No idea — yet."

Calibrated Updates · Labelling confidence in work reporting

- "Here is what is confirmed, and here is what is still assumption."
- "I am confident on cost, less so on timeline — the risk sits there."
- "Two things I know and one I do not — let me take them in that order."
- "I would put roughly seventy per cent confidence on that estimate."
- "The honest status: on track for scope, uncertain on the integration date."
- "The data supports the first claim; on the second we are still guessing, and I want to label it as guessing."

Warm Honesty · Not knowing, said with care

- "I honestly do not know what I would do in your shoes."
- "I do not have an answer — but I am happy to sit with the question with you."
- "I wish I could promise it will be fine. What I can promise is that you will not face it alone."
- "I do not know enough to advise you, but I know enough to listen."
- "My honest answer is that I am not sure — and I would rather give you that than something polished."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Bluffing: 'Yes, I believe that would be around...'
Better: I am not entirely sure — my best guess would be...
Best: I do not know that. I can find out by X and come back to you.
2. Weak: Apologising excessively for not knowing
Better: I am sorry, I do not have that.
Best: I do not know — and I do not want to guess. What I can say is...
3. Weak: Saying you do not know but then speculating anyway
Better: I am not sure, but maybe...
Best: Stop at 'I do not know.' Add only what you genuinely know.

DECISION TREE

If You are asked something you do not know

Say you do not know. Name what you do know. Offer to find the answer.
"I do not know that. What I can say is X. I can check and confirm by end of day."

If You have a partial answer and are tempted to fill in the gap

Give the partial answer and name the boundary.
"I know X but I am not confident about Y — I do not want to guess at that part."

If You are an expert and feel pressure to have all the answers

Your credibility is built on accuracy, not omniscience. Name what you do not know.
"In my field, the honest answer here is that we do not know yet."

If They seem disappointed you do not know

Hold the uncertainty rather than backfilling with speculation.
"I understand you need a clearer answer — I would rather give you the right one."

SCENARIOS

Interview question outside your knowledge

State the boundary of your knowledge confidently. Offer what you can. — "That is at the edge of my area — I do not want to give you an unreliable answer. What I can say is..."

Client asks a technical question you cannot answer

Admit the gap, confirm what you know, commit to finding out. — "I do not have that number with me — I will confirm it today. What I can confirm is X."

Meeting where you are expected to have information you do not

Do not pretend. Name what you have and what you are missing. — "I do not have the full picture on this yet — I can give you what I have and flag the gaps."

Being asked for an estimate you cannot give confidently

Give a range with explicit uncertainty rather than a false precision. — "My rough estimate is X — but I want to flag that I am not confident in that figure."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Stakeholder: What's the delivery date?
You: (guessing) March.
(In February, you have to revise to May. Trust is damaged.)

With the technique

You: I don't have a reliable number yet — my rough estimate is Q1 but there are two dependencies I haven't resolved. I can give you a firm date by Thursday.

Stakeholder: Thursday works.

COMMON MISTAKES

Bluffing under pressure

Sounds like: 'Yes... it should be around the fifteenth, probably, yes.'

Better: 'I do not want to give you a date I cannot defend. I will confirm one tomorrow.'

Apologising for the gap

Sounds like: 'I'm so sorry, I feel terrible not knowing this...'

Better: 'I do not have that yet. Here is when I will.'

Speculating straight after admitting

Sounds like: 'No idea — but if I had to guess, probably about forty?'

Better: If you must estimate, label it plainly: 'A guess only, and treat it as one: around forty.'

Uncertainty with no plan to resolve it

Sounds like: 'Yeah, we just don't know.' — end of answer.

Better: 'We do not know yet. Here is how and when we will find out.'

Blanket uncertainty as a shield

Sounds like: 'Hard to say, could go either way, who knows.'

Better: 'I am confident about the cost. My genuine uncertainty is only about the date.'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- People trust your answers more because they know you say when you do not know.
- Your 'I do not know' is accepted rather than treated as evasion.
- You feel more credible after admitting uncertainty, not less.
- Conversations stay grounded in what is actually known.

Signs to adjust

- You use 'I do not know' as a dodge when you actually have a view.
- Uncertainty is not being followed by any commitment to find the answer.
- Your tone sounds apologetic rather than confident.
- You are uncertain about things you should know by now.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the audience needs a definitive answer to proceed and further uncertainty will paralyse decision-making.
- In contexts where expressing uncertainty is read as incompetence — some cultures and hierarchies require stated confidence.
- When you actually are certain — false modesty obscures clear information.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'That number was a guess dressed up as a fact — I want to correct that now.'

- "I gave you a firmer answer than I actually have. Let me redraw the line: the first part is solid, the second is not."
- "That number was a guess dressed up as a fact — I want to correct that now."
- "I said I did not know and then speculated anyway. Please strike the speculation."
- "I have been hedging on something I am actually sure about. Plainly: yes."
- "I sounded apologetic just then. To be clear, not knowing this yet is the honest position."
- "I committed to finding that out and have not yet. Here is a new time you can hold me to."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Pressed-for-an-answer chain

Name the known -> name the unknown -> commit to a time -> hold under pressure

What I can confirm is that the fault is in the payment layer.

What I cannot yet tell you is how many customers were affected.

I will have that figure by five.

I would rather give you a right answer at five than a wrong one now.

Estimate chain

Give the range -> label the confidence -> name the moving parts -> offer the firm date

My working estimate is six to eight weeks.

I would call that medium confidence.

The swing factor is the third-party API — we have not tested against it yet.

After next week's testing I can give you a date to plan around.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC023 — Bounded Deferment

Bounded Deferment turns a named unknown into a commitment — 'I will come back to you by X' is the natural next sentence.

TC008 — No-Overexplaining Discipline

No-Overexplaining Discipline keeps the admission clean — nerves want to bury 'I do not know' under speculation.

TC031 — Slow Down Under Pressure

Slow Down Under Pressure protects the steady delivery that makes uncertainty read as precision rather than panic.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the bluff

Notice one moment today when you gave a confident answer you were not actually certain about.

Day 2 — Name the boundary

In one conversation, say 'I do not know' rather than bluffing or hedging.

Day 3 — What you do know

After admitting uncertainty, name specifically what you do know — no broader than what you can stand behind.

Day 4 — Commit to finding out

After every 'I do not know', offer a specific time by which you will come back with the answer.

Day 5 — Tone check

Say 'I do not know' confidently — not apologetically. Notice how it lands differently.

Day 6 — Expert context

Use confident uncertainty in a context where you are expected to be the expert.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did 'I do not know' land well? Did you follow up on things you committed to check? Did credibility improve?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I say 'I do not know' directly rather than hedging or bluffing?
- Did I name what I do know clearly?
- Did I own the gap confidently rather than apologetically?
- Did I commit to finding the answer and follow through?
- Did I avoid speculating after admitting I did not know?
- Did my tone stay grounded rather than nervous?
- Did people seem to trust my honesty rather than lose confidence in me?